imports from Cuba into the United States were prohibited (including Havana cigars). Washington's allies were pressured to stop trading with Cuba. This met with mixed success (the British were, in particular, hostile to US interference in their trade with Havana). And a series of military exercises were conducted, including those designed to rehearse US invasion plans. In October 1962 a Marine Corps amphibious assault exercise was scheduled for the island of Vieques near Puerto Rico.

The failure at the Bay of Pigs provided a huge boost for Fidel Castro. The US-sponsored intervention consolidated Castro's rule and enhanced his international status. In mid-August 1961 a White House aide, Richard Goodwin, attended a meeting of the Alliance for Progress in Montevideo in Uruguay. He was approached by Che Guevara who mischievously thanked him for the Bay of Pigs.[86] The failed operation also reinforced Havana's relationship with Moscow. In April 1961, for the first time, Castro referred to the Cuban revolution as 'socialist.' In December he announced that he was, and would always be, a Marxist-Leninist. Khrushchev had told Kennedy in Vienna in June 1961 that Castro was not a communist – 'but you can make him one'.[87] Later, Fidel would maintain – with less plausibility – that he had been a Marxist-Leninist all along, and that his professions of more utopian socialism were tactical ruses.

Debate about the failure of Operation Zapata focused on responsibility for specific aspects of the operation (including the choice of the Bay of Pigs and the failure to provide air cover for Brigade 2506), as well as the more fundamental misjudgement in believing the landing would spark an uprising that would overthrow the Cuban government. Nothing has emerged to suggest an uprising was likely to have happened. Unless the 'assassination track' was part of the enterprise, the plan was fundamentally flawed. It might be argued that similar CIA escapades, such as in Guatemala, were equally incredible, but nevertheless successful. Yet, to launch an operation that cost so many lives and so damaged the credibility of the US government seems an extraordinary lapse of judgement and responsibility.

Afterwards, JFK posed the rhetorical question to Ted Sorensen – 'How could I have been so stupid?' There is no record of a reply. For Kennedy, the stupidity lay in accepting the advice of the CIA (and the Joints Chiefs).